



INTERJECTIONS

The short bursts of emotion or reaction in speech

1 What is it?

Interjections (in-ter-JEK-shunz)

An interjection is a short word or phrase used to express sudden emotion or reaction — like surprise, pain, joy or hesitation. It usually stands alone, often followed by an exclamation mark.

short burst + shows a feeling

2 See it in action

Surprise

"**Wow!** I didn't expect that."

Pain

"**Ouch!** That really hurt."

Hesitation

"**Um,** I'm not sure about that."

Agreement

"**Yes!** That's exactly right."



Look here!

Read a piece of dialogue aloud — the interjections are usually the words that sound most like real spoken reaction.

3 More to know

Disgust

"**Ugh,** that smell is awful."

Relief

"**Phew!** We made it just in time."

FUN FACT

"Ouch" is thought to come from the German word "autsch", brought into English by German immigrants in the 19th century — before that, English speakers more commonly said "ow" alone.

4 Why it's used

Interjections help: capture natural, spontaneous emotion in dialogue and speech — they make writing (especially character dialogue) feel real and alive.

Interjections are grammatically independent — they don't connect to the rest of the sentence the way other word types do, and are common in speech but rare in formal writing.



Good spot!

Save interjections for dialogue and informal writing — they'll stand out awkwardly in an essay or formal report.

5 Where you'll spot it

In dialogue

Characters say 'Oh!', 'Ugh' or 'Wow' to react naturally — a common feature of scripts, comics and story writing.

With punctuation

Usually followed by an exclamation mark for strong feeling, or a comma for a milder one: 'Well, I suppose so.'

⚠ Watch out!

Interjections are almost never appropriate in formal or academic writing — save "wow", "ugh" or "oh" for dialogue, informal writing, or direct speech only.

6 Quick recap

Shows sudden emotion

Stands alone in a sentence

Mostly used in speech/dialogue



Quick reminder!

An interjection followed by an exclamation mark ('Wow!') shows strong emotion; followed by a comma ('Well, maybe.') shows a milder one.